

Biomes

The same type of habitat, such as a desert or tropical rainforest, can occur in different parts of the world. These habitats—called biomes—look alike, even though different animals may live there. Each color on this map represents a different land biome.

Tundra



Close to the poles, conditions are so cold that the ground is frozen for much of the year, so few trees can grow. This open landscape, home to animals such as Arctic hares, is called the tundra.

Mediterranean woodland



Woodland trees with thick, leathery leaves grow in places with warm, dry summers and mild winters, such as in the Mediterranean home of the asp viper, as well as in southern Africa and southern Australia.

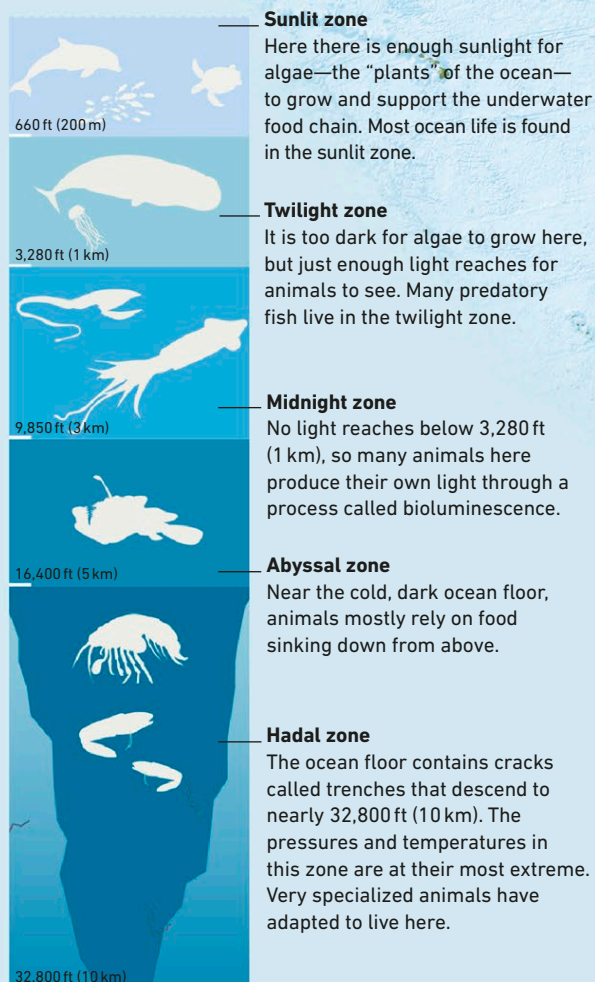
Taiga



Covering the largest land area is a stretch of cold, northern forest called taiga. It is dominated by evergreen coniferous trees, and is home to many animals, such as the wolverine, which range widely south of the Arctic.

Ocean habitats

Conditions in ocean habitats are affected mainly by depths: animals living in deeper waters must cope with higher pressures, colder temperatures, and perpetual darkness.



Temperate forest



Much of the forest in this temperate zone has trees that are deciduous, growing leaves in the mild summers and losing them in cold winters. North American porcupines and other animals that live here must cope with seasonal changes.

Temperate grassland



Grasslands usually grow when conditions are too dry for forest but too wet for desert. Temperate grasslands—home of the prairie chicken—are warm in summer and cold in winter, but stay green all year.

Tropical grassland



In the tropics, many grasslands are at their greenest during the rainy season. In places such as Africa, they support some of the biggest herds of hoofed mammals, including wildebeest, zebras, and giraffes.